

# Marxist criminology

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## Introduction

Marxist criminologists take a structural approach to the study of crime, which is quite different from most mainstream criminologists, who tend to focus on individuals (e.g. variants of control theory, rational choice theory, and psychological theories of crime). Marxist criminologists argue that crimes committed by individuals or organizations cannot be understood without analyzing the context of the society in which they occur, which often puts them at odds with those working in other theoretical traditions. Because Marxian explanations of crime focus on economic structures that are either taken for granted, or assumed to be inherently good, non-academics unfamiliar with Marxian theory often dismiss them outright. The fact notwithstanding that many sociological and liberal-leaning criminological theories agree with Marxists (at least in part) by taking into account the role of economic structures in their attempts to explain crime, Marxist criminology has never gotten a strong foothold in the broad field of criminology, or in the realm of public policy.

The development of Marxist criminological theory has further been complicated by the fact that neither Marx nor Engels wrote extensively on the subject, as both were primarily concerned with the socio-historical development of capitalism. Crime, for Marx and Engels, was a by-product of the ways that economic systems reproduce themselves, and they argued that some systems such as capitalism had the potential to create more class conflict (and crime) than others.

These problems raise three particularly salient points for a Marxian analysis of crime. First, it isn't just generic "capitalism" that causes crime. Rather, one must analyze particular capitalist economies in terms of their social institutions, class conflict, contradictions, and attempts by the state to temper the most pernicious effects of their economic arrangements. For instance, although the countries of Western Europe and the United States all have capitalist economies, one can easily argue that there are far fewer economic safeguards provided in the United States than in Western European countries (e.g. universal health care, subsidized housing and welfare). As Hall and McLean (2008) write:

In the industrialized West the most striking distinction in homicide rates can be found between, on one hand, the American neo-liberal form, and on the other the

social democratic and corporatist forms that, although currently under pressure from the global hegemony of neo-liberalism, still characterize Western European nations. (p. 314)

Second, the development of any particular capitalist economy is not stable or uniform for long periods of time. Marxists generally agree that capitalist economies rest on fundamental contradictions, which in turn create dilemmas for the state, which must then be resolved (Chambliss, 1993). Because the contradictions do not disappear, new dilemmas continually arise that must be resolved. These contradictions are “antagonisms or conflicts between different elements in the existing social arrangements that in the long run are incompatible with one another [and will] tend to destabilize society” (Greenberg, 1981, p. 16). Resolutions to dilemmas are inherently political, and so very different responses to similar dilemmas that occur at different times may be proposed. Marxist criminologists, then, must pay particular attention to the socio-historical context within which crime occurs.

Third, for a Marxist criminology to have even a minimal influence on crime policy, those working in the field will have to integrate key insights from other theoretical traditions, while at the same time overcoming long-standing biases and misunderstandings from those both in and outside criminology. As left realists and other critical criminologists have argued, narrow (overwhelmingly conservative) political interests have dominated crime control policy (Matthews, 2009).

In what follows, I will trace the development of Marxist criminology, not only noting the development of the field, but also highlighting disagreements among Marxist criminologists themselves. I will then turn to an analysis of what Marxist criminologists have studied, paying particular attention to areas that have been most fruitfully analyzed. Finally, I will offer suggestions for future development of Marxian criminological perspectives. I will argue that the Marxian approach is still relevant and useful to understanding not only varieties of crime, but also state responses to crime.

## Marx, Marxists, and crime

As previously mentioned, Marx did not develop a systematic theory of crime. Engels, his close friend and writing partner, did write a bit more extensively about crime in *The Condition of the Working Class in England in 1844*. As Taylor, Walton, and Young (1973) summarize Engels' view, “crime appeared largely as a form of ‘demoralization’: a collapse of men’s humanity and dignity, and in index, too, of societal decline” (p. 209). Although both Marx and Engels were critical of the ways in which life under industrial capitalism stripped away the dignity and humanity of the working class, and created the “dangerous class” of the lumpenproletariat (e.g. outcasts, beggars, petty criminals, who are not part of the working class), they did not more carefully examine the ways in which capitalism creates opportunities for crimes by the dominant class.

The working class or the lumpenproletariat does not commit all crimes, and many critical criminologists would argue that the most harmful crimes are actually committed by corporations or nation-states. What Marx and Engels provided, though, was a very insightful critique of the ways in which capitalism reproduces itself. It is from this reproduction that various forms of crime emerge as capitalist economies struggle to reconcile their inherent contradictions.

Willem Bonger is often credited with being the first Marxist criminologist because he attempted to link crime explicitly to social and economic structures in his book *Criminality*

*and Economic Conditions*. For Bonger (1916), crime generally arose from the egoism (self-interest) that is generated within capitalist systems. Bonger noted that the social relations under capitalism weaken altruistic tendencies while exacerbating egoistic ones through increased competition and class conflict. Importantly, Bonger argued that this is true for all classes, even the ruling class.

Georg Rusche and Otto Kirchheimer continued advancing a Marxist criminology in *Punishment and Social Structure*, arguing that each system of production creates forms of punishment to correspond with its productive relationships. Rusche and Kirchheimer (1939) claimed that large quantities of surplus labor in the market would lead to harsher penal policies, in part as a means to keep labor costs down by reducing the surplus labor force. In the broadest sense, periods of high unemployment should also have higher incarceration rates and longer sentences. However, as Michalowski and Carlson (1999) discovered, the relationship between “punishment and social structure is likely to differ between different SSAs [social structures of accumulation],” and there are important differences between various periods within capitalist systems (p. 240).

During the 1970s and 1980s, a number of critical criminologists attempted to further develop Marxist criminology. Notable among those early works was *The New Criminology* by Taylor, Walton, and Young (1973). Dissatisfied with the development of criminological theories that focused on individual pathology and the state’s official views of crime, Taylor et al. (1973) were the first to develop a radical criminology that argued for a “political economy of criminal action, and of the reaction it excites, and for a politically-informed social psychology of these ongoing dynamics” (p. 279). In short, Taylor et al. (1973) challenged criminologists to develop fully social theories of crime that located the causes of deviance and crime squarely within existing social arrangements.

## Structural and instrumental Marxism

The development of Marxist criminology has been contested terrain, and has not been as straightforward as one might think. Like any other theoretical perspective, scholars working in the field engage in serious debates over theoretical issues. Marxist criminologists, for example, have debated questions such as: Is the law simply a reflection of class interests used by the ruling classes to control those beneath them? Should criminologists accept the state’s definition of crime? Are those who engage in street crime actually revolutionary? Should Marxist criminologists study traditional street crime or white-collar crime (or both)?

One of the more pivotal developments within Marxist criminology has been advancement in theorizing about the role of the state in maintaining social arrangements that preserve power and privilege for the ruling class. Early attempts in this area often maintained that the law and institutions of criminal justice are primarily instruments used by the state to maintain ruling-class dominance (Quinney, 1974). Early attempts to theorize the role of the state and law in class domination viewed the state as having relatively little autonomy from the interests of the ruling class, with the law as a “tool” of the ruling class (Quinney, 1974). This perspective has often been called instrumental Marxism.

There is some utility to the instrumentalist perspective, in that one can find particular examples of laws that enhance the dominance of the ruling class at the expense of the rest of society. However, the instrumentalist perspective has been criticized for overstating the cohesiveness of the ruling class, and its ability to make the law serve its interests (Greenberg, 1981). Therefore, instrumental Marxism has been rejected in favor of more nuanced understandings of class, the state, and law. One such development can be seen in the later work



of Chambliss (1993), who argued that the primary role of the state is to preserve the system itself. As he suggested, the inherent contradictions of the system create dilemmas that must be resolved. Depending on the circumstances, laws and policies may be enacted that actually favor the working class, especially in those instances where not appeasing them may undermine the system (e.g. labor laws, unemployment benefits). On the other hand, the state has been slow to apply criminal law to the behaviors of corporations, has generally not treated white-collar criminals as harshly as street criminals, and has not defined its own behavior as criminal.

## **What should Marxist criminologists study?**

### *What is a crime?*

If criminology is the study of crime, what definition of crime should be used? This question has been debated for a long time, within both critical and mainstream circles. Many critical criminologists have challenged the use of state definitions of crime as the state often fails to categorize all harmful acts as crimes (Hillyard, Pantazis, Tombs, & Gordon, 2004; Schwendinger & Schwendinger, 1970). Others have argued that many state definitions of crime are useful, and have adopted more “legalistic” approaches to studying crime (Kauzlarich & Kramer, 1998; Kramer, 1982; Matthews & Kauzlarich, 2007). Although a complete discussion of this debate is beyond the scope of this paper, a few quick points are in order. First, there is nothing in Marxist theory that suggests those studying crime should reject the criminal law outright. As Bonger (1916) pointed out long ago, many laws define as criminal acts that are hostile to the preservation of *any* society (e.g. murder, assault, and other violent crimes). Second, although not rejecting the law outright, Marxist criminologists need to pay careful attention to the ways in which the law is applied to acts that have similar outcomes, the ways in which class protects people from the full force of the law, and the ways in which the state itself is not held accountable for its obligations to other forms of law, such as international law (Matthews & Kauzlarich, 2007). Therefore, Marxist criminologists are not precluded from studying corporate crime, state crime, or any other crimes of the powerful. Nor are they confined to studying only crimes of the powerful – traditional forms of street crime are also of interest (Carlson & Michalowski, 1997; Hall & McLean, 2008; Matthews, Maume, & Miller, 2001; Michalowski, 1985).

### *The criminal justice system*

While studying the role of law in preserving the political economy is one subject of Marxist inquiry, another has been the criminal justice system itself (Chambliss, 2001; Reiman & Leighton, 2010). At every stage in the criminal justice system, from the making of law to sentencing, class plays an important role in how severely criminals are punished (Cole, 2000). The United States, for example, has the highest per capita rate of imprisonment of any advanced capitalist country at 750 per 100,000, far outpacing its closest rivals (Cowling, 2008). Some estimates place the total number of people imprisoned in the United States at well over 2 million, with another 5 million under some kind of correctional supervision (Herivel & Wright, 2007). Herivel and Wright (2007) estimate that, “with just 5 percent of the world’s population, [the United States] incarcerates 25 percent of the world’s prisoners” (p. ix). Although some of those in prison are there for serious, violent offenses, many are



there for drug or property crimes. Further, as Clear (2007) has noted, most of the growth in the prison population “has had little to do with crime; rather it has been the product of a series of policy changes” (p. 49).

The United States has incarcerated an incredible number of its citizens, most of them from poor urban minorities (Clear, 2007; Western, 2006). Many have termed this phenomenon “mass incarceration.” According to Western (2006), young black men are “six to eight times more likely to be in prison than whites” (p. 16). If the United States incarcerated whites at the same rate as minorities, the number of prisoners would swell to over 6 million, accounting for nearly 5 percent of the working-age population (Western, 2006). Although Western’s (2006) analysis of this problem is not Marxist in nature, he does suggest that the roots of it are in the social structure, writing that:

Unemployment, family instability, and neighborhood disorder combine to produce especially high rates of violence among young black men . . . their unemployment rates have been double that of whites since the 1970s. High rates of black unemployment accompany large numbers of female-headed households and neighborhoods of concentrated poverty. (p. 36)

From a Marxist perspective, the ballooning prison population in the United States over the past 20 years may be viewed as a result of changes in the economic structure. As Carlson, Gillespie, and Michalowski (2010) argue, the repressive penal policies that began in the 1980s have their genesis in “stagflation,” the “unprecedented occurrence of high official unemployment rates and double digit inflation” (p. 248). During this time, many urban areas were undergoing rapid deindustrialization, in which companies closed manufacturing plants in the United States and moved them overseas. With the loss of high-paying, low-skill jobs, many communities saw an unemployment spike, with accompanying increases in violent crimes related to the underground drug economy (Currie, 1993). Both conservative and liberal politicians have endorsed repressive policies to control crime – particularly mandatory sentencing. According to Carlson et al. (2010), this increased the proportion of the surplus population being incarcerated, which aided profit realization for capitalists in three important ways. First, these policies expanded employment within the criminal justice system, with the need for more police, corrections, and court officials. As Carlson et al. (2010) note, the number of people employed in the judicial/legal part of the system alone increased by over 50 percent between 1982 and 1992. Second, as the incarcerated population grew, the “state and federal prison system became an increasingly lucrative market for goods and services produced/provided by private corporations” (Carlson et al., 2010, p. 250). Third, these repressive policies gave the appearance of a return to “social harmony,” which “contributed to restoring investor confidence that had been badly eroded by the social and economic disruptions of the [previous] decay phase [of capital accumulation]” (Carlson et al., 2010, p. 250).

### *Corporate crimes*

Critical criminologists have long argued that corporate crimes are far more harmful, in terms of both lives lost and property stolen, than street crimes. Despite these costs, Friedrichs (2009) has suggested that it is much more difficult for criminologists to accurately determine the extent and costs of corporate crimes because access to data is limited, there are no

uniform practices for collecting data, a significant amount of the harm is indirect, and much corporate crime either goes unreported or is undetected. Although a data source comparable to the Uniform Crime Reports (which catalog street crimes) does not exist for corporate crimes, many have turned to case studies to uncover the various harms caused by corporate crimes. These harms include those caused to the environment, consumers, and workers (Friedrichs, 2009).

Like street crimes, corporate crimes arise within particular socio-historic settings. Often, state agencies that are supposed to regulate corporate crimes actually facilitate or initiate them. One way in which state agencies facilitate corporate crimes is by not enforcing regulatory laws intended to curb corporate behavior that may be dangerous. For example, 25 workers were killed, and another 56 were injured, after a fire broke out at the Imperial Food Products chicken processing plant in Hamlet, North Carolina, in 1991. Many workers were trapped inside the burning plant because the doors had been locked to prevent employees from stealing chicken nuggets (Aulette & Michalowski, 2006). The state of North Carolina did not fully fund its Occupational Safety Health Program, which in turn did not enforce safety laws that would have prevented Imperial Foods from locking the fire exits. As Aulette and Michalowski (2006) note, state and federal organizations

pursued a pattern of actions and relations that made it possible and routine that workers in the Imperial chicken processing plant would be denied adequate escape routes in case of fire. This pattern does not represent an aberrant moment in North Carolina labor history. Rather, we argue that it was a reflection of North Carolina's long-standing commitment to development policies based on attracting industry by offering low taxation and, particularly relevant in the immediate case, a lax regulatory environment. (p. 46)

There are many cases in which corporations have committed crimes because of the failure of state regulatory agencies to adequately rein in harmful behavior they knew was occurring (Michalowski & Kramer, 2006). Sometimes the harm is caused by lax oversight, other times state agencies collude with corporations to cause harm (Kauzlarich & Kramer, 1998). Other times, states have committed crimes with the help of corporations (e.g. the corporations that worked with the Nazis to make gas chambers, knowing full well what they would be used for). From a Marxist perspective, the nexus between state agencies and corporate interests is of utmost importance in developing an understanding of corporate and/or state crime.

### *Street crimes*

Left realists have pointed out that, although corporate crime may cause more harm than street crime, the harms of street crimes are no less significant. Marxist explanations of street crime tend to focus on the ways in which economic conditions foster criminal activity. For example, as economic conditions deteriorate and unemployment rates rise, crime rates tend to increase. Crime rates tend to be higher in the most severely economically disadvantaged neighborhoods, which often suffer from a myriad of other social problems, which create what Ian Taylor (1999) insightfully termed "structures of disadvantage." As Carlson and Michalowski (1997) have found, the relationship between unemployment and crime is likely to vary depending on the prevailing social structures of accumulation in a capitalist economy at any given time.

As the perpetrators and victims of most crimes are from the same neighborhood, those who are most economically disadvantaged are also most likely to be the victims of crime, a point made by many left realists. Although some early Marxist theorists mistakenly romanticized street criminals as “revolutionaries” reacting against an unjust economic order, the left realist critique has shown that there is nothing revolutionary about predatory behavior that victimizes the most economically disadvantaged members of society (DeKeseredy & Schwartz, 2010; Matthews, 2009; Young, 1997). Rather than provide the impetus for revolutionary thought, fear of street crime is probably more likely to play into the hands of the capitalist class, both strengthening their grip on social institutions and policies, and expanding public support for increased forms of social control that extend far beyond violent crimes. Such policies take scarce dollars from essential public programs such as education and shift them to burgeoning criminal justice agencies such as prisons, which is all the more likely to create more, and more pronounced, “structures of disadvantage.”

### Neo-liberalism, market societies and Marxism

As Cowling (2008) notes in his excellent overview of the development of Marxist criminology, there has been an overall decline in the amount of work carried out in the area during the past two decades. There are likely several reasons for this, most relevant among them that, under the broad umbrella of “critical criminology,” there have been many theoretical advancements over the past 30 years, in areas such as feminist criminology, postmodernism, deconstructionism, and cultural criminology, to name a few. In a practical sense, these perspectives are competing with each other and Marxism for favor among a relatively small pool of potential critical criminologists in graduate programs throughout the world. In addition, Marxist criminology has been criticized by some feminists for being gender blind, and insensitive to issues of race. Although there is room for theoretical integration between some of these perspectives, Marxism is sometimes viewed as stubbornly privileging class over gender and race, if not outright ignoring them. Finally, Marxism may be viewed as passé, having been one of the perspectives that deeply influenced the development of early critical criminologists, but now out of favor following the collapse of communism and the alleged triumph of capitalism. However, as the financial events of recent years have painfully shown, a critique of political economy is relevant now more than ever.

As with any theoretical perspective, there is always a need to update and reconsider. The dialectical nature of capitalism means that change is constant, and new developments must be brought into the theoretical fold. Additionally, the good theorizing and research carried out by earlier Marxist criminologists must be updated in light of changes in political economy, both in particular countries and globally. For example, the bulk of the theoretical work carried out by Marxist criminologists occurred either before or during the radical changes brought by the advent of neo-liberalism in the 1980s. There is little doubt that the neoliberal project that began in the 1980s has had a tremendous effect on many capitalist societies, with

The deregulation of business, the privatization of state enterprises and responsibilities, the dismantling of social programs, the expansion of market forces into new corners of society, a much-weakened trade union movement, the return of unrestrained competition, and the rebirth of previously rejected free-market economic theories. (McDonough, Reich, & Kotz, 2010, p. 9)



The neo-liberal project, and its emphasis on deregulating industry, curbing the power of labor unions, resource extraction from developing countries, and near religious faith in the power of the “free market” to govern nearly all forms of human relations, has caused much social, political, and environmental destruction. This destruction can be seen in various degrees in the decaying inner cities of many capitalist countries throughout the world, with all their attendant social problems such as crime and poverty, and the responses by policy-makers that range from indifference on one hand to cutting social programs while increasing punitive responses to crime on the other. It can also be seen in the harms caused by corporations operating in an increasingly unregulated environment. It can be seen in the sacking of the financial markets, with the reckless decisions made by large banks, insurance companies, and investment firms that brought the global economy to the brink of collapse. As Currie (2004) documented, it can also be seen in the disintegration of many middle-class families, which have become “sink or swim” institutions themselves. Finally, neo-liberalism has brought with it an incredible transference of wealth, with the gap between the wealthiest countries (and individuals) and the poor being wider than at any time in modern history. Although there are many ways in which neo-liberalism can be analyzed, it is arguably most productively analyzed using the tools of Marxist theory. Marxist criminologists would do well not only to describe the effects of neo-liberalism on crime (street as well as corporate) in particular capitalist countries, but also to compare them with those in other capitalist countries where the most extreme outcomes of neo-liberalism have been resisted somewhat (e.g. comparing the United States with Western European countries, or Japan).

During the current neoliberal era, the balance of power between workers and employers has shifted dramatically to employers, and capitalism has become more globally integrated, and has also become more financialized (McDonough et al., 2010). Class antagonism appears to have diminished with the weakening of labor unions and an increased sense of individualism, which is combined with a general lack of collective concern. Alarming, what little collective concern remains that is vocal and organized appears centered around anti-government or anti-immigration movements promoted by various right-wing groups. Finally, the “unqualified ideological emphasis on the sovereignty of the consuming individual” has increasingly become the organizing principle of the neoliberal social order, with dire consequences for traditional forms of community values (Taylor, 1999, p. 137).

Many capitalist economies have undergone radical changes since the bulk of Marxist criminological theory was written in the 1980s. In what ways have those changes impacted impoverished communities and crime? In what ways have those changes created opportunities for corporations to commit crimes? How much damage to community, civic, and communal life has flowed from these changes? In what ways has extreme inequality exacerbated racial tensions? As males commit most crimes, in what ways have these structural changes influenced how gender is conceptualized and practiced? How has the victimization of women by men been effected by challenges to projects of hegemonic masculinity brought about by decreased opportunities in the labor market? How has the withdrawing of public dollars to help those who are disadvantaged furthered alienation and despair in poor urban areas? What is the consequence of societies that are organized no longer around production, but rather around consumption? This basic list of questions is by no means exhaustive, and yet much work remains to be done in answering them.

Most of the noteworthy attempts to answer these kinds of questions during the past 30 years have been by Elliot Currie (1985, 1997, 2004) and the late Ian Taylor (1999) in their analysis of “market societies,” as well as by many of the left realists (DeKeseredy

and Schwartz, 2010; Matthews, 2009; see also the left realism chapter in this volume by DeKeseredy and Schwartz). Again, although a full treatment of these works is beyond the scope of this chapter, and the degree to which either of these authors would self-describe as Marxist is debatable, a brief treatment should give the reader a sense of how Marxists might incorporate the insights from these authors in their analysis of crime.

In his classic work *Confronting Crime*, Elliot Currie (1985) argued that the “egoism” that Bonger (1916) wrote of near the turn of the century was a driving force behind the (then) emerging neoliberal order, and was responsible for high levels of crime in impoverished urban areas. Currie (1985) presciently wrote that:

Seventy years ago, the noted Dutch criminologist Willem Bonger warned that a single-minded emphasis on market values breeds crime because it “weakens the social instincts of man.” The United States has always been distinctive, even among other societies based on market capitalism, for the intensity of that emphasis and the absence of countervailing traditions and institutions to mediate and humanize it . . . in a society that values its people for what they can acquire rather than what they contribute and that encourages predatory and manipulative behavior in the service of immediate gain as the guiding principle of economic life, we should not be altogether surprised if more explosive forms of the same ethos are expressed among the most deprived. (p. 277)

Currie went on to expand his concept of market societies in later works, notably his article in *Theoretical Criminology* (Currie, 1997). In this work, he outlined an explanation of high levels of violence in post-industrial societies, arguing that market societies organized around “the pursuit of private gain” were more prone to high levels of violence because their social institutions and arrangements were being transformed in ways that not only created incentives and opportunities for violence, but also diminished traditional mechanisms of public support that might have reduced them.

Along similar lines, Taylor (1999) argued that the very organization of economic life had changed (e.g. from industrial to post-industrial, and from production to sale), giving rise to post-Fordist market societies. The cultural characteristics of the market society reflect a harsh version of social Darwinism, giving ideological justification to the economic basis of neoliberal capitalism, which in turn results in many forms of criminal activity. Although not new, the current variant of social Darwinism manifested in market societies gives expression to the most competitive, indulgent, and individualistic tendencies of capitalist economies while at the same time diminishing regard for social responsibility (Currie, 2004). This ideology pervades the thinking not only of individuals, but also of social institutions, ranging from politics to the family (Currie, 2004). Taylor (1999) analyzed both street and corporate crime within the context of market society, giving a significant (and prescient) treatment to financial fraud arising from the deregulated, highly competitive, and shortsighted interests of those working in finance.

### Future directions for Marxian criminology

Anyone interested in pursuing Marxist criminology should review Cowling’s (2008) *Marxism and Criminological Theory: A Critique and a Toolkit*, which is likely the most current and comprehensive treatment of Marxist criminology available. Cowling’s (2008) recommendations for advancing Marxist criminology include further developing and refining the analysis of the following: the ways in which capitalist systems reproduce themselves, the



role of the institutions of criminal justice in that process, and the role of law in capitalist societies.

One simple yet productive area of Marxist inquiry may be to revisit the earlier works of Marxist criminologists and update them in light of recent changes in social institutions. As previously mentioned, the changes brought about by neo-liberalism have created radical social, political, and cultural shifts in many advanced capitalist societies. Although post-modernist Zygmunt Bauman (2004) has given articulate expression to the conditions of contemporary globalization and the “wasted lives” it produces, Marxists must look for ways to anchor such powerful insights within the project of modernity. For example, the post-industrial nature of many advanced capitalist countries such as the United States means that they have economies that are based, in large part, on complex forms of financialization. Lying in the shadows of these new economic arrangements are vast deindustrialized wastelands, marked with many social problems such as crime, poverty, and persistent unemployment. These problems didn’t simply emerge from thin air. Nor are they an “unfortunate but unavoidable” consequence of economic progress. In short, Marxist criminology, now more than ever, represents a powerful counter-perspective to the prevailing belief that “no better alternative exists” to unregulated economies that allow, in the infamous words of Reiman and Leighton, “the rich [to] get richer and the poor [to] get prison.”

In addition to these areas of inquiry, I would add the following: rather than developing rigid (and perhaps simplistic) Marxian interpretations of crime, Marxist criminologists should look for new ways to integrate key Marxian concepts with current research and theorizing. For example, there has been a great deal of empirical work done by liberal and mainstream criminologists documenting changes in criminal justice policy over the past 30 years (e.g. mass incarceration, changes in sentencing such as mandatory minimums and increased spending on criminal justice). Rather than let this growing body of empirical work speak for itself, Marxist and Marxist-inspired criminologists should recast these findings in Marxian terms (e.g. mass incarceration, the increased expenditures in criminal justice fields, the privatization of segments of the criminal justice system). Also, left realists such as DeKeseredy and Schwartz (2010) have attempted to link neoliberal economic policies to hegemonic masculinity, in an attempt to show that “left realism is not incompatible with a gendered understanding of crime, law and social control” (p. 80). The same is true of Marxism, and, as feminist scholars have long argued, there is ample room to develop Marxian critiques that carefully consider the role of gender in crime. There is still much work to be done in the area of state–corporate crime, given the ever-increasing power of corporations and influence on governments around the globe. For instance, analyzing the recent bubble economy, and the severe social dislocations caused by the “casino capitalists” in finance (and the role of neoliberal proponents of deregulation) over the past ten years, would give Marxist criminologists enough work to keep them busy for the next decade.

Finally, in reference to theory, Marxist criminologists must work with those in other disciplines who are advancing Marxist theory in *general* (see Carlson et al., 2010). If the beginning point to understand and explain crime from a Marxist perspective is political economy – that is, crime as a symptom of the underlying socio-economic conditions of a given society – then understanding changes in political economy are more important than thinking about crime itself. In other words, our understanding of crime is more likely to be advanced when we begin by placing it within a particular set of social arrangements rather than focusing on crime and criminals. Understanding changes in these social arrangements



over the past 30 years (since the bulk of Marxist criminology was written) may be the best place to begin.

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